show that he belonged to a tribe designated in the government gazette as an ‘agricultural’ tribe. [3] The condition prevented the transfer of land to a person outside the agricultural community. [4] When the Hindu commercial classes, who monopolized money-lending in Punjab, failed to mobilize the cultivators against the legislation, an emboldened Punjab government went on to pass additional bills. These strengthened the position of a small aristocratic class at the expense of the peasantry. In order to amend the Punjab Colonisation of Land Act 1893, the Punjab Land Colonisation Bill 1906 was introduced in the legislative council on 25 October 1906, and then passed in February 1907, as already recounted. Some twenty years earlier in 1887, the Punjab government had embarked upon the Chenab Canal Colony project. Yet, the problem was that not only were these reforms promulgated very fast, but they were also so far-reaching that the government was able to extend its reach right into the heart of the daily life of the peasant grantees. This is what proved intolerable for the yeomanry. They were told that they had to live on their land, cut wood from specified areas, maintain a clean compound and have arrangements made for sanitary disposal of night soil.

The colonization officer and his subordinate Indian staff supervised all aspects of colony life. They made sure that the colonizer fulfilled all the conditions. The grant of an absolute power made the officer a virtual dictator. His word was final in any dispute. The ‘fine system’, compulsory tree planting, sanitary rules, transfer of land by will and a higher occupancy fee were included in the contracts after 1902, which took a heavy toll on the peasant farmer. Moreover, only strict primogeniture, as interpreted by the canal officer, would be permitted in the future. [5] And, if a new settler died without gaining occupancy rights (which was generally before five years) the land lapsed to the government, which reserved the right to re-allot the property to lineal heirs or to unrelated tenants. [6] Fines were legalized, and the courts were prevented from interfering with executive orders. What the government of the day failed to realize at the time was that ‘the year 1906 was the wrong time to present a measure extending official powers’ because there was ‘discontent over maladministration in the colony which had been spreading since 1900’, when the Punjab Alienation of Land Act of that year